



French 101: Café de la Place — A Full Conversation Session

French 101 • French

COURSE-OBJ.FR101.2

Use beginner French accurately and politely to greet, introduce yourself, order at a café, and ask simple questions about people and preferences. A complete 90-minute session packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner/lab work, independent practice, extension work, assessment, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the session

Course and objective

French 101 · French; COURSE-OBJ.FR101.2 — Exchange greetings, personal information, and café requests using polite expressions, articles, and the present tense of être, avoir, and -er verbs.

What is included

Cover; instructor guide; key-term and concept preview; original reading or worked examples; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner/lab discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group extension work (4 items); assessment; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (90-minute session)

Warm-up 8 min · dialogue read-aloud + vocabulary 15 min · guided grammar organizer 20 min · partner role-play 15 min · independent practice 20 min · extension work 8 min · assessment 4 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key, or distribute through a secure LMS. Review the reading/examples and organizer before class. No paid textbook or app is required.

Student directions

Read or work through the material carefully. Support every answer with evidence, work shown, or clear reasoning.



Before you begin

Key terms

bienvenue — welcome

vous êtes combien ? — how many are you? (party size)

rendez-vous — appointment / meeting

je voudrais — I would like

avoir faim / avoir soif — to be hungry / to be thirsty (literally, "to have hunger/thirst")

comment allez-vous ? — how are you? (formal)

nerveux / nerveuse — nervous

de rien — you're welcome

Concept focus

Être (to be) and avoir (to have) are irregular and among the most frequent verbs in French; most other present-tense verbs follow the regular -er pattern (parler → je parle, tu parles, il/elle parle, nous parlons, vous parlez, ils/elles parlent). Definite articles (le, la, les) and indefinite articles (un, une, des) must agree in gender and number with the noun. Politeness markers (s'il vous plaît, merci, vouvoient with vous) are expected in service and academic contexts.

Model 1 — Conjugate parler for je, nous, and ils.

je parle, nous parlons, ils parlent — regular -er pattern: drop -er, add -e, -ons, -ent.

Model 2 — Why does "café" take "un" but "eau" typically appears as "une eau" in a request?

"Café" is a masculine noun so it pairs with "un"; "eau" is feminine, so it pairs with "une" — gender is a property of the noun itself, not something chosen freely.

WARM-UP

Warm-up

Answer using what you already know or recall from the previous session.

1. What explicit question does the server ask when Inès and Marcus arrive?

2. Translate Inès's response: "Nous sommes deux."



Au Café de la Place (Partie 1)

SERVEUR : Bonjour ! Bienvenue au Café de la Place. Vous êtes combien ?

INÈS : Bonjour, monsieur. Nous sommes deux. Mon ami et moi, nous avons rendez-vous avec notre professeur.

SERVEUR : Très bien. Une table près de la fenêtre ?

MARCUS : Oui, s'il vous plaît. C'est parfait.

SERVEUR : Voici le menu. Vous désirez boire quelque chose ?

INÈS : Je voudrais un café, s'il vous plaît. Et toi, Marcus ?

MARCUS : Moi, je voudrais un thé et un croissant. J'ai très faim ce matin.

SERVEUR : Très bien. Et pour vous, mademoiselle ?

INÈS : Un café et une eau, s'il vous plaît.

SERVEUR : Parfait. Ça arrive tout de suite.

Au Café de la Place (Partie 2)

(Le professeur arrive.)

PROFESSEUR OKONKWO : Bonjour, Inès ! Bonjour, Marcus ! Comment allez-vous aujourd'hui ?

INÈS : Je vais très bien, merci, madame. Et vous ?

PROFESSEUR OKONKWO : Je vais bien aussi, merci. Alors, vous êtes prêts pour l'examen de vendredi ?

MARCUS : Nous sommes un peu nerveux, mais nous étudions beaucoup.

PROFESSEUR OKONKWO : C'est bien. Vous avez des questions sur les verbes être et avoir ?

INÈS : Oui ! J'ai une question. Pourquoi dit-on "j'ai faim" et pas "je suis faim" ?

PROFESSEUR OKONKWO : Excellente question. En français, on utilise "avoir" pour la faim, la soif, et l'âge — pas "être", comme en anglais. "J'ai faim", "j'ai soif", "j'ai vingt ans."

MARCUS : Ah, je comprends maintenant. Merci, madame.

PROFESSEUR OKONKWO : De rien. Bon appétit, tous les deux ! On se voit vendredi.

INÈS ET MARCUS : Merci, madame. À vendredi !

Guided practice · Reasoning organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

Given / Evidence	Method / Reasoning	Conclusion
State the given information, quote, or data.	Explain the method or reasoning in your own words.	State the answer or claim it supports.

1. Which verb (être or avoir) does Marcus use to explain he is hungry, and what is the exact phrase?

2. Why is "j'ai faim" grammatically correct while a literal word-for-word translation using "être" would not be, according to the professor's explanation?

3. Conjugate avoir for j', tu, and vous, citing one example of each from the dialogue.

4. What does Inès order, and what article precedes each item?

Partner / lab discussion

Discuss each item with a partner or lab group before writing a joint response.

1. Why does "café" take "un" and "eau" take "une"? Explain using grammatical gender.

2. What polite phrase does Marcus use when ordering, and what does it mean?

3. Identify one example of vouvoiement (formal "you") in Part 2, and explain why it is used instead of tutoiement.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

1. What question does Inès ask the professor about grammar, and how does the professor respond?

2. Conjugate être for je, nous, and ils/elles, citing one dialogue example for at least one form.

3. What explicit feeling do Marcus and Inès express about the upcoming exam, and in what sentence?



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

4. Identify the verb "étudier" in context and explain what conjugation pattern it likely follows.

5. Translate the professor's closing line: "On se voit vendredi."

6. Write a two-line greeting exchange between a student and a café server, using vous.



Small-group extension work

Use for review or additional application practice.

1. Write a short French sentence ordering a drink and a food item, using "je voudrais."

2. Explain, in English, the difference between "un/une" and "le/la" as used in this dialogue.



Small-group extension work

Use for learners ready for additional challenge or synthesis.

1. Rewrite "Je voudrais un thé" using "avoir envie de" (to feel like/want) instead of "voudrais."

2. Why might a French instructor consider this dialogue useful for practicing both être and avoir in the same scene?

Assessment

Complete independently to show what you learned today.

1. Write a full four-line dialogue exchange, in French, ordering a meal and responding to "Comment allez-vous?"



Assessment · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this before the next session.



Answer key

1. "Vous êtes combien ?" (How many are you?)
2. We are two. / There are two of us.
3. Avoir; "J'ai très faim ce matin" (I am very hungry this morning).
4. French uses avoir (to have) for expressions of hunger, thirst, and age, unlike English, which uses "to be"; the professor explicitly explains this as a fixed idiomatic pattern, not a free choice.
5. j'ai (j'ai faim), tu as (used implicitly with "toi, Marcus" context — accept correct form), vous avez (vous avez des questions) — all forms shown or implied in the dialogue.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. Un café et une eau — "un" (masculine, café) and "une" (feminine, eau).
7. Every French noun has a grammatical gender; café is masculine so it pairs with "un," and eau is feminine so it pairs with "une" — the article must agree with the noun's gender, not with logic about the object itself.
8. "S'il vous plaît," meaning "please" (formally, literally "if it pleases you").
9. The professor and students use "vous" with each other in most exchanges (e.g., "Comment allez-vous?"); vouvoiement is used because it reflects the respectful student-professor relationship, unlike the informal "tu" Inès and Marcus might use with each other.
10. She asks why one says "j'ai faim" instead of "je suis faim"; the professor explains that avoir, not être, is used for hunger, thirst, and age in French.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. je suis, nous sommes ("Nous sommes deux"), ils/elles sont — the nous and (implied) plural forms appear in the dialogue.

12. They feel a little nervous: "Nous sommes un peu nerveux, mais nous étudions beaucoup."

13. "Nous étudions" (we study) follows the regular -er verb pattern, similar to parler: étudier → j'étudie, nous étudions, etc.

14. We'll see each other Friday. / See you Friday.

15. Answers vary; must use formal "vous" and an accurate greeting-response pattern, e.g., "Bonjour, vous êtes combien?" / "Bonjour, nous sommes trois."

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Answers vary; must use "je voudrais" plus correctly gendered articles, e.g., "Je voudrais un chocolat chaud et une baguette."
17. "Un/une" are indefinite articles (a/an), used for ordering an unspecified item, like "un café"; "le/la" are definite articles (the), used for a specific, already-known item — the dialogue uses indefinite articles because the items are being requested for the first time.
18. J'ai envie d'un thé. (Note the elision of "de" to "d'" before a vowel.)
19. Because it embeds both verbs in natural, connected contexts — being polite and describing feelings (avoir faim, être nerveux) — rather than presenting them as isolated conjugation drills, helping students internalize real usage patterns.
20. Answers vary; must include a greeting, a response to "Comment allez-vous?", a food/drink order using "je voudrais" or "j'ai envie de," and a polite closing.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

Extension

Ask for a second method, a counterexample, or a short student-led extension of the concept, with a brief explanation of the choice.

Accommodated seating/504

Follow the individual accommodation plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

Additional support

Pre-teach key vocabulary or notation before class. Model the first guided item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

Multilingual learners

Preview key terms with examples. Allow brief first-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence or solution starters.

Course-level alignment · accessed September 18, 2026

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Course-level learning objective written for this packet; no accreditation, transfer credit, or universal course-equivalency is claimed.

Original reading(s)/worked examples, questions, and answer explanations. No textbook or copyrighted course material reproduced.

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